Bitch Boxer

By Charlotte Josephine

(Chloe walks on stage carrying a jump rope. She has one hour until her fight; the qualifier for the Olympics 2012. She stands center stage and is still for a moment taking in her audience. She begins skipping and the sounds slowly fade until she is alone. She is professional and focused, skipping center stage facing the audience. The skipping builds in speed and intensity becoming very fast and furious until it suddenly stops and she drops the rope to the floor. She stands still, breathing hard until she has caught her breath and can speak. If her hood to her hoodie hasn't already fallen down she pulls it back off her face.)

CHLOE: I'd woken up well late. Knew it was late before I looked at my phone. Ten, twenty-seven. Blind panic as I jump outta bed and run round the house trying to tidy up/make breakfast and get dressed at the same time. Multi-tasking to the max. I jump out the front door to stick the rubbish in the bins. I actually thought to myself wouldn't it be funny if, when I heard the door shut. Click.

INTRODUCTION

Professor Neal Roese of Northwestern University found that in his 2012 study, this biggest regret of all, the regret that derives from the loss of loved one, is the most crippling. However, if we accept the lessons from our regrets, we become motivated to improve ourselves to ultimately meet our goals. Because in the end, we decide whether our regret debilitates us, or propels us.

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CHLOE: Ah, no way. You gotta be joking. But no. I'm officially locked out. And it's half ten in the morning/ I've got to be at the gym in an hour and my dad will kill me if I'm late.

I quickly hatch a plan. I reckon I can climb onto the outhouse thing we got at the back of our house 'n' try my bedroom window which is always open. But I gotta ask next door if I can hop their fence. I knock next door, but there ain't

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no answer. By now I'm panicking. Three doors down and some woman opens the door. She finds it funny, leads me across her garden and gives [me] a leg up. "Good Luck!"
"Cheers love." Fence number one done.

The next one is high, it makes the most sense to balance on a little boy's bike and climb up the fence onto the shed next door. This I do, no problem, my upper-body strength is in top condition. Dropping down off the shed roof I land on the concrete when I hear that very/ distinct/ pad/ of feet. I turn slowly. It's a pit-bull. It rubs it's hairy head on my bare leg. Somehow I don't get bit. I back away. Never taking my eyes of the dog.

(Breath out and launch into next section.) Up and over the fence, this one is rotten, a real stunner, the green mossy wood snaps under me cutting my stomach and scratching my legs. But I'm here.

(Smile.) I made it. I shimmy up the drainpipe. Surprising myself with a new-found-talent. I scramble up the roof, and I make it to the window. I see my keys on my bedroom floor next to my handbag. Next to me on the roof is a whole load of metal poles/ from when Dad was decorating. I have a moment of genius. Involving some keys, a metal pole, and a handbag. Results! Keys in my mouth/ I wiggle down the drainpipe. I am very proud of myself. I feel liberated/ like a super hero. I get in and check the time, I did all that in a half an hour! Ladies and Gentleman, Gold medal Olympian Chloe Jackson! Oh yes, I am the best/ I am the champion of cat burglars! The phone rings, "Yes mate! You will never guess what has just happened to me/ seriously/ I just. What?" And then he tells me. Dad's dead. Just like that. Two words. *(Pause)*

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I hate funerals. Nah really/ I don't get it. All that money spent on flowers. My dad never bought no one flowers, so why now all of a sudden was he getting hundreds of 'em? Everyone turned up, all the kids from the gym, their parents, their parent's parents. If you wanna spend your money spend it down the gym/ that's what he'd ave wanted. Not on flowers! And everyone kept hugging me all the time, crying on me, telling me what a terrible waste it was. Yeah you're right/ I wanted to say, waste of money on all [these flowers]. And I could tell they were watchin' me, all sly like, out of the corner of their eyes. Waiting for me to crumble.

(Pause) When you've been a fighter all your life it's hard…When Dad died I just had to get on with things/ No amount of crying is gonna bring him back so I didn't let 'em fall.

Ma left us when I was eleven. Buggered off with some bloke she'd met in Tesco. My dad was gutted. Like, she taken his heart [and] stamped on it.

(Beat) Came home from school and my dad was sat on the sofa/ *crying.* *(beat)* He stayed like that for two weeks/ that's how much he loved her. [Me?] I smashed the house up. *(Beat)*

[But] dad knew what to do. Took us down the gym. Stopped me smashing things up round the house and started me training. Taught me to control my anger. Focus it in to Power, strength and speed. Just me and my dad fighting the world together/and I loved it. And low and behold, natural talent.

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I'd slip my hand in Dad's whilst we walk and he'd look down at me and smile. I grew up a bit/ I still held his hand. Liked the feel of it. Got to that age where I didn't want to hold Dad's hand anymore, wasn't cool. I could tell that he was hurt by it, but he never said nuffink. *(Beat.)*

I was 'bout eighteen year old. Sweating away working the bags, He approaches, "*Come on then kid, show me what you got.*" Two blocks/ two straights/ two body shots. "*Good.*" He says. "*You're in Clo, women are gonna fight in the Olympics 2012.*" And whooping with delight we ran round the gym laughing/ And without saying a word, it was all agreed. I'm gonna fight at the Olympics. We made battle plans like it was Waterloo. Stuck charts up on the wall, every competition one step closer to my new dream. A chance to prove to the whole world I'm worth sumionk, to prove 'em all wrong. Women can't box? You watch. *(Beat.)*

Months of training, and this is it. The two of us the same. Both bringing our A-Game to this one shot we both got at the title. I'm quickly learning her habits. The tiny pop-up she does with her shoulder before she throws a right, the shift in weight to duck and dive that leaves her open. I widen my eyes and blink hard, sweat is stinging but I keep them on her.

We wait for the bell [and break].

She's in her corner listening to her coach. Her face, eager for some words of wisdom. He demonstrates what he wants her to do. She smiles and nods, he pats the side of her face and smiles back, placing his forehead onto hers for a moment. It's suddenly clear, that he's her dad. *(Break, big push)*

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I wish I'd never been embarrassed. I wish I'd been proud of holding Dad's hand 'cause yeah I miss it now. And I regret it now. I wish I'd just held my dad's hand forever.

(Chloe caught in the ropes)

What do I do? Dad!

(Chloe still caught on the ropes) "Keep your head down Chloe and look for an opening."

(Chloe finds a way out; one series of hard jabs that seems to take all of her energy.)

And I suddenly realize I - could – win - this. *(She knocks her opponent out. She celebrates, her hand in the air. As the noise of the crowd dies down her smile fades slightly. She is alone and winning is suddenly bittersweet.)*

Apparently he did watch. Snuck in the back. Wouldn't have missed it for the world. *(Beat)* . . . Funny thing. You get a knock in life, and it winds you for a moment/ you can't breathe, but you pick yourself back up and you get your game face on. *(Beat.)*

When people ask me what my dad was like I don't really know what to say, do you know what I mean? I mean what was your dad like? Oh yeah? Good for you. My dad was just my dad you know, nothing special. I mean yeah, he was special to me/ but then I'm bound to say that, ain't I? *(Beat)*

[My dad always said]: Chloe: It ain't gonna be easy. "You've got to fight for the things you love."

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AWARD HISTORY

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**NOTE: Words in [ ] are added to the script for ease of transition*

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